1.1 From Farm to Factory

On a farm or in a factory—where would you rather work? In the first half of the 1800s, new inventions sparked the growth of factories. Many people left farm life behind, and this shift changed American culture in many ways.

MAIN IDEA Industrialization in the early 19th century transformed the ways in which Americans lived and worked.

CHANGES IN THE ECONOMY

In the early 1800s, different regions of the United States became more interdependent and connected. One factor that made this possible was the **market revolution**, or the transition from a pre-industrial economy to a market-oriented, capitalist economy. In part, this economic transition was prompted by the **Industrial Revolution**, or the widespread production by machinery, that had been underway in Europe since the mid-1700s.

The beginning of the Industrial Revolution in the United States is often dated to 1793, when **Samuel Slater** opened his first cloth factory in Rhode Island. Industrialization in the Northeast transformed social structures and had important consequences for the nation's economy and international position.

Newly introduced machines produced goods more rapidly and efficiently than people could make by hand, one at a time. A **factory system**, or a method of production in which large crews of people perform work in one location, developed. Mechanized production in factories and mills replaced skilled craftspeople. Factory managers recruited men and women from rural areas, many of whom embraced the idea of factory work.

New locations and types of work profoundly affected how people lived and worked. They also transformed the family economy. Furthermore, instead of working together on farms or in shops, men and women began to work in separate spheres. This shift was especially true for the emerging middle class.

THE MILL GIRLS

The United States entered the Industrial Revolution through the **textile** industry, which produced cloth and clothing from cotton and other raw materials. Initially, individual workers wove thread into large pieces of cloth on hand-operated looms. In 1785, an Englishman named Edmund Cartwright introduced the first power loom. Power looms required multiple workers, but by 1813, improvements had eliminated the general need for all but one person. This single-operator model became the basis for a faster, more efficient power loom developed by **Francis Cabot Lowell** at his textile mill in Massachusetts.

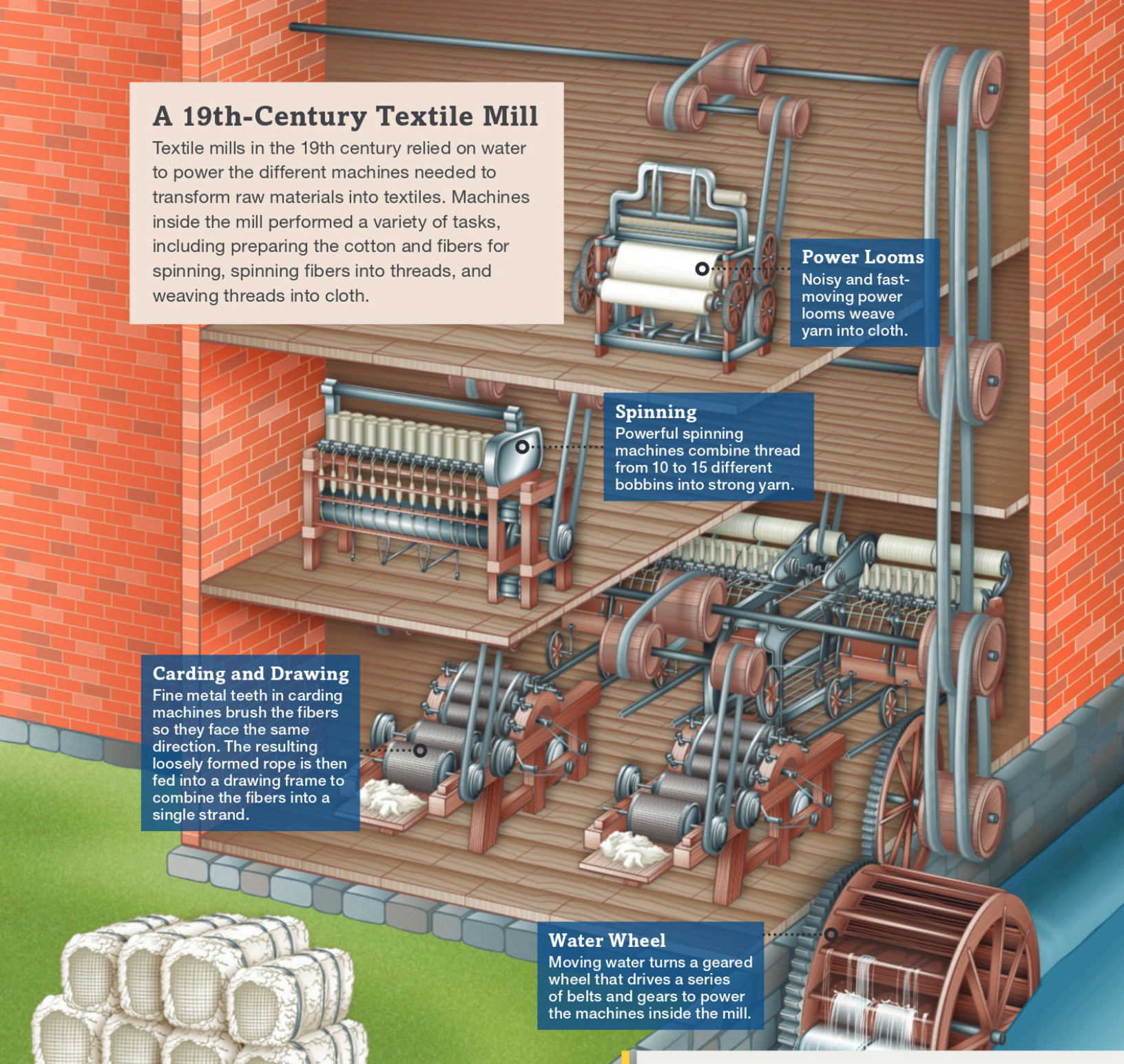
A mill town named in Lowell's honor was founded in 1823. Mill owners hired young girls and women because they would work for less pay than men. These female textile workers, some as young as 10 years old, were called the "Lowell girls." The Lowell girls lived in boarding houses and worked in the mills instead of attending school. Their letters home revealed that many enjoyed the independence factory work provided. These young women also published a monthly magazine of poetry and fiction, called the *Lowell Offering*.

Eventually, the Lowell workers' low wages and long hours in dangerous conditions soon became intolerable, so the young women banded together to protest. In the 1830s, the Lowell workers organized several **strikes**, or work stoppages, to protest cuts in wages. Their activism led to the formation of the Lowell Female Labor Reform Association, the first organization of working women in the United States.

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A 19th-Century Textile Mill

Textile mills in the 19th century relied on water to power the different machines needed to transform raw materials into textiles. Machines inside the mill performed a variety of tasks, including preparing the cotton and fibers for spinning, spinning fibers into threads, and weaving threads into cloth.



Power Looms
Noisy and fast-moving power looms weave yarn into cloth.

Spinning
Powerful spinning machines combine thread from 10 to 15 different bobbins into strong yarn.

Carding and Drawing
Fine metal teeth in carding machines brush the fibers so they face the same direction. The resulting loosely formed rope is then fed into a drawing frame to combine the fibers into a single strand.

Water Wheel
Moving water turns a geared wheel that drives a series of belts and gears to power the machines inside the mill.

Raw Materials
Bales of cotton arrive at the mill via horse-drawn wagon.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did work change in the early 19th century?
2. **INTERPRET VISUALS** Based on the illustration and captions, describe how raw materials were transformed into cloth at textile mills.
3. **DETERMINE CHRONOLOGY** In what ways did the establishment of mill towns in the northeastern United States rely on earlier economic and technological developments?

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